Management of diabetes

Lifestyle modifications play an important role in the prevention and treatment of diabetes than in any other disease. Balancing diet, exercise and drug along with appropriate stress coping skills will ensure better diabetic management.

The main modes of treatment are:

- Diet
- Exercise
- Drugs
- Education

A. Dietary Management

A balanced diet rich in complex carbohydrates and fibre, low in simple sugars and saturated fat with moderate protein facilitates good glucose control. Regular use of fresh foods like fruits and vegetables with limited use of processed foods is recommended.

Energy

The total energy intake should be sufficient to meet individual needs for normal growth and development, physical activity and exercise and maintenance of a desirable body weight.

Even amounts of food should be eaten at regular intervals throughout the day, to prevent fluctuations in the blood glucose level, especially hypoglycaemic (low blood glucose level). Snacks between meals may be needed to prevent fluctuation in the blood glucose level.

Carbohydrate

An intake of 55-60% of total calories is recommended to improve glycemic control. Complex carbohydrates found in whole grains, pulses, vegetable and fruits are preferred. Root vegetables can be taken in moderation while simple sugars like sugar, honey, jaggery and processed refined cereals should be restricted.

DO YOU KNOW?

Glycemic index

The extent of rise in blood glucose levels in response to a food in comparison with the response to an equal amount of glucose is known as glycemic index. Generally, complex carbohydrates are considered to have a low or moderate glycemic index, while simple sugars have high glycemic index.

Fibre

An intake of 25-50g of dietary fibre is considered optimal. Fibre present in vegetables, fruits, legumes and fenugreek seed is soluble in nature and more effective in controlling blood glucose and lipid levels (reduce total cholesterol and triglycerides) than the insoluble fibre present in cereals. High fibre diets also promote weight loss.

Protein

Consuming protein at levels of 20 % of total calories is recommended. Protein along with carbohydrate will lower blood glucose level.

Fat

No more than 25% of the total calories should come from fat as high fat diet increases the risk of heart diseases. Polyunsaturated fatty acids and Mono unsaturated fatty acids present in vegetable oils are preferred to saturated fatty acids that are found in meat and egg.

Salt

A moderate to low salt is recommended to lower high blood pressure.

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